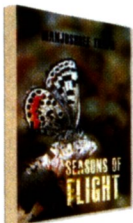


# Divided SELF

Love and loss in Nepal and Los Angeles as a young woman finds her place in the world

| By Anagha Neelakantan |



SEASONS  
OF FLIGHT

by MANJUSHREE  
THAPA

Penguin/Viking

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Manjushree Thapa's *Seasons of Flight* is many things—a love story, an immigrant's tale, a matter-of-fact telling of the costs of war, a manifesto for environmental conservation, a meditation on faith and chance. A 215-page novel could sag under the burden of such weighty themes, but Thapa pulls them together flawlessly. Prema is a Nepali woman in her mid-20s who moves to Los Angeles after a chance application wins her the green card lottery. In doing so, she leaves behind a father and village she has already been separated from by the war; a career in forestry; a lover she admires but excludes from her decision to leave. She leaves with a sense of bewilderment and powerlessness in the face of the war increasingly encroaching upon her life. But there is little premeditated or rationalised about her departure. Instead, random circumstances come together to make it seem the only choice.

The narrative switches between Prema's departure and early days in Los Angeles, and her present. Along the way, she realises she wants to truly inhabit America but cannot or does not think about how. She simply moves away from Little Nepal, as well as the Nepal of her mind, not contacting her father, or reading news on the Internet. Then, into her regimented, spare life as caretaker for an ageing woman comes Luis Reyes, a California mutt with a dead Guatemalan father. Prema finds affirmation of life in sex, and the possibility of belonging, in Luis's multicultural, blithely consuming America.

But the forced breaks with her past are obstacles to her ability to truly be in her new world. Prema's life is too fragmented, and the ghosts of her past are never far, describing tight ellipses around her present. Her loss in childhood of her

mother to childbirth is reflected in her growing ambivalence about conventional relationships. Her shutting out of Nepal's troubled present is manifested in a reluctance to explain where she is from and her hunger to understand the profound human experience of war is displaced on to Guatemala, as she reads all she can find about the country and its conflict. Her career as a forester in Nepal asserts itself in her interests in Los Angeles' wetlands and the city's threatened biodiversity. Prema breaks up with Luis, determined to try and find her place in the world and a sense of self. A chance encounter with an environmental lawyer sets her onto the path of building bridges between her past and present, and balancing randomness and deliberation. In making sense of her own and her country's troubles, Prema learns to live more fully. She begins to inhabit a wider swathe of the world, to reach out to people, and to see the interconnections between all the elements that sustain and challenge her life.

*Seasons of Flight* is about both fleeing and soaring, about the transience of situations and physical reality and the persistence of universal human and natural experiences. At a time when being apolitical is often celebrated, Thapa does a fine job

of describing how politics, even when tangential, can change a person's life and is therefore worth understanding. It is populated with vivid, believable characters and Prema herself is finely drawn, all the more credible for not always being the hero of her own life. Admirers of the style and passion of Diane Ackerman and Rachel Carson will find echoes of the two in Thapa's writing about the pull of the natural world. *Seasons of Flight* is a great read from a distinctive and elegant writer at the top of her game.

(The writer's *A Half Revolution: Nepal at War and Peace is out soon*)

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